



**INDUSTRIALIST-
MP JAY PANDA
OWNS A FIRM
THAT HIRES OUT
HELICOPTERS**

FOR THE **NON-PERFORMERS** AMONG MINISTERS, HELICOPTER RIDES ARE NOT **MERELY A LUXURY** BUT ALSO HELP IN AVOIDING THE WRATH OF THE PEOPLE.

This indicates chaos in the state secretariat. Ministers have hired helicopters for routine engagements like attending rallies and inaugurating school buildings. Besides, there are ministers who use the Maoist threat as an excuse to hire helicopters. Minister for Energy and Culture S.N. Patro was supposed to go to Gajapati district in central Orissa for some official functions by road but decided to hire a private helicopter. He forwarded a note saying the superintendent of police of the area had informed him over phone about a landmine threat. The flying visit went through and government paid Rs 2,74,220 for the arrangement.

NCP leader Bijoy Mohapatra, a Patnaik critic, says misuse of helicopters indicates how luxury-minded the Cabinet has become. "I used to obtain information from government departments and highlighted it. But as it be-

came an embarrassment for the chief minister, who has carefully cultivated an image of a man of simple living, all channels of information were blocked suddenly," adds Mohapatra, a former ministerial colleague of Naveen's father Biju Patnaik.

The princely lifestyle of ministers does not suit poverty-stricken Orissa. Besides, flying to even short distances by chartered helicopters also helps these non-performing ministers to keep away from the people, Mohapatra says. "Once you travel by road you will face people and will have to answer their queries about development or lack of it," he adds. Finance Minister Prafulla Chandra Ghadai, reputed to be one of the richest politicians in Orissa, does not agree. "It's ridiculous to think that ministers live a lux-

urious life," he says, arguing that ministers hire helicopters with prior approval of the chief minister to visit only far-off places. "We can't afford to spend more time unnecessarily outside the state capital. Besides, under Naveen babu, all ministers are expected to lead a simple life," he adds.

Only a couple of years ago, the chief minister along with Ghadai was credited for bringing along a fiscal turnaround that had impressed even the World Bank. "Real growth reached an average of 8.4 per cent over the past years; ahead of the all-India average," says Ghadai.

Nine years in power and Patnaik continues to be an embodiment of simplicity in his trademark white kurta-pyjama and Kolhapuri chapals. He often says that "the beauty of Orissa camouflages its acute poverty". It can't be seen from a great height either. ■